

Éti in Martinican Creole: Functions and origins of a “martinicanisme”

Martinican Creole (MC) is a French-based Creole in which one word, *éti*, has been associated with a wide range of functions. Its hypothesized origin is the French interrogative phrase *Où est-il ?*, reanalyzed in earlier French varieties and grammaticalized in MC as *wéti*. Related forms occur in other French-based Creoles, including *oti* in Haitian Creole (Librova 2021), though these do not span the same range of functions as *éti*.

In current descriptions, *éti* can serve as a locative interrogative or a relative particle. It may also appear as an oblique relative pronoun as in *Fanm-la (éti) ou ka palé mwen an.*¹ (Pinalie & Bernabé 1999: 35) or next to the optional object/subject relative pronoun *ki* as in *Boug-la (éti) (ki) ka mennen loto wouj la...*² (Bernabé 1987: 89). In this context, scholars disagree whether *éti* is the expletive and *ki* the true relative marker (Bernabé 1987), or the reverse (Librova 2021). This ambiguity underscores the need for a closer look at *éti*'s behavior.

Our corpus comprises articles published in the magazine *Kréyolad* (2004–2021) and from *Montray Kréyol* online, extracted by a web scraper. Sentences containing *éti* totaled over 500 occurrences. We analyzed (i) *éti*'s functions, attested and unattested; (ii) its syntactic contexts; and (iii) whether specificity in the antecedent was relevant for *éti*'s presence.

Results confirm all functions previously described in the literature, while revealing additional ones. These include (1) a temporal relative function and (2) a complementizer function:

- (1) ...sé an prenses karayib an tan **éti** [...] péyi-nou an té ni an bel soukramétan dianman anlè'y... (c.35)
“...she’s a Caribbean princess at a time **when** [...] our land was covered in beautiful diamonds.”
- (2) Man fè sé touris-la konprann **éti** nou té adan an sel LIANNAJ épi Lagwadeloup... (c. 394)
“I made the tourists understand **that** we were in one sole League with Guadeloupe...”

Preliminary findings show *éti* occurring more frequently in relative functions, particularly following direct or indirect object antecedents; here it almost always follows a [+specific] antecedent, but we have yet to confirm whether *éti*'s presence depends on specificity. Therefore, in this work, we focus on *éti*'s role as a relative pronoun and complementizer, including the distribution of subject vs. object relatives, antecedent type, and specificity. Finally, we consider whether the full range of functions can be attributed to the grammaticalization of a single morpheme, or whether they point to two homonymous morphemes of distinct historical origins.

¹ “The woman you are telling me about.”

² “The man who is driving the red car...”

References

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